

First ultrasound scan

Your first scan at 10–14 weeks can pinpoint the length of your pregnancy to within a five- to seven-day window. Such accurate dating helps estimate your due date and determine the right time to perform tests later in pregnancy.

Your first scan

This ultrasound helps to accurately establish your baby's gestational age. This is particularly useful if you are not sure of the date of your last menstrual period, if you have irregular periods, or you became pregnant immediately after you stopped using contraception such as the pill. At this stage of pregnancy, your baby can be measured from crown to rump (from the top of the baby's head to its bottom).

Accurate dating of your pregnancy is important not only for establishing your due date and the timing of screening and diagnostic tests, but also because it helps to avoid misdiagnosis of problems such as poor [fetal growth](#). Your due date will usually be changed at this scan if there is more than a five- to seven-day difference between your menstrual dates and the dates based on the crown–rump length.

A scan may be given before 10 weeks if you have bleeding or pain to rule out the possibility of a miscarriage or [ectopic pregnancy](#).

How the scan is done During an ultrasound scan, high-frequency sound waves are emitted through the abdomen via a handheld device called a transducer. As the sound waves hit solid tissue, they translate into an image that is viewed on a computer screen and interpreted by the sonographer.

At this scan, you will need to drink plenty of water to raise the uterus and provide a clearer image. The sonographer will put some cold gel on your abdomen to maximize contact with the skin and will then move the transducer gently over the area.